

UI/UX Design Planning Guide

Note-taking app · Infinite canvas · Page rotation · Cloud sync

Design starts	Figma handoff	Total screens	Dev starts
Day 1	Day 14	22 screens	Day 15
Week 1 kickoff	End of week 2	All flows	No overlap

PHASE 1 — RESEARCH & DISCOVERY

1	Research & Discovery Understand users before designing anything	Days 1–2
Day 1	Competitor study Install Samsung Notes, Noteshell, GoodNotes, Notability. Screenshot every screen. Write what works and what frustrates you. Focus on how each handles canvas and page management.	
Day 1	User pain points list Read Play Store / App Store reviews of competitor apps. List the top 10 complaints. These become your design opportunities — e.g. page limit, no rotation, slow sync.	
Day 2	Define user personas Write 2 personas: (1) Student — needs infinite horizontal space for mind maps. (2) Professional — needs cloud sync across phone, tablet, and laptop. Each persona: name, goals, frustrations, devices.	
Deliverable: 1-page research doc with competitor screenshots + 2 personas. Share with developer before design starts.		

PHASE 2 — INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

2	Map every screen and how they connect Do this on paper or FigJam before opening Figma	Day 3
Step 1	List every screen the app needs (full list below)	
Step 2	Draw a user flow map — arrows showing how a user moves screen to screen for each task	
Step 3	Mark which screens are MVP and which are v2 — do not design v2 screens now	

MVP screens to design (22 total)

Splash / onboarding	Sign in / sign up	Home / notebooks list
Notebook detail	Note canvas (main screen)	Tool palette (pen/text)
Page rotation UI	Horizontal page strip	Page settings
Search notes	Sync status	Connected devices
Profile / account	Pro upgrade / paywall	App settings

Export options	Delete confirmation	Empty states (x3)
Loading / sync states		

PHASE 3 — WIREFRAMING

3	Wireframing Layout first, visual design second — grayscale only	Days 4–5
Rule	Grayscale only Use only gray boxes, lines, and placeholder text. If you are thinking about colors, you are doing it too early.	
Focus	Canvas screen Spend 60% of wireframe time on the canvas screen. Tool placement, gesture hints, and page strip position must be resolved here.	
Key Q	Page strip placement Where does the horizontal page strip live? Bottom bar? Side panel? Swipe gesture? Answer this in wireframes.	
Key Q	Rotation button Where does the rotation button go without cluttering the canvas toolbar?	
Deliverable: Low-fidelity wireframes for all 22 screens in Figma. Get developer sign-off before moving to visual design.		

PHASE 4 — DESIGN SYSTEM SETUP

4

Build once, use everywhere

One full day — do not skip this, it saves 3x time later

Day 6

Color palette	Primary, neutral, error, success — define hex values for each
Typography scale	Heading, body, caption, label — font size + line height for each
Spacing system	4px base grid — use 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32px only
Corner radius	Small 4px / Medium 8px / Large 16px — as tokens
Button variants	Primary, secondary, ghost, danger — all states including disabled
Input field states	Default, focus, error, disabled — cover all four
Icon set	Pen, eraser, text, color picker, rotate, export, sync — custom or library
Bottom nav bar	Reusable component with active/inactive states

Tip: Use a free Figma community design system as a base (Material 3 or Untitled UI) and customise it — do not build from scratch.

PHASE 5 — HIGH FIDELITY DESIGN

5	High Fidelity Design Apply visual design to all 22 screens — most important first	Days 7–11
Day 7	Canvas screen — both states Empty state (first launch) + active state (with notes, tool palette open, page strip visible). This is your hero screen — make it look premium.	
Day 8	Home + notebook screens Notebooks grid/list, recent notes, search bar. Think of this like a file manager — clean, scannable, fast to navigate.	
Day 9	Onboarding + auth screens 3-screen onboarding showing infinite canvas, rotation, and cloud sync. Sign in / sign up with Google and Apple. Target: under 30 seconds to get through.	
Day 10	Settings + account + paywall Profile page, connected devices, sync status, Pro upgrade screen. The paywall screen needs extra care — this is where revenue is made.	
Day 11	Empty states + loading + export Users see empty and loading states constantly. Design them with care. A well-designed empty state prompts users to create their first note.	
<i>Deliverable: Design at 390x844px (iPhone 14 base). Flutter adapts to other sizes. Design both light and dark mode for the canvas screen.</i>		

PHASE 6 — PROTOTYPE & HANDOFF

6	Prototype & Handoff Make it clickable, then hand it to the developer	Days 12–14
Day 12	Figma prototype Connect all screens with click interactions. Minimum: tap notebook opens canvas, tap new page adds to strip, tap rotate rotates canvas. Share prototype link with developer.	
Day 13	Annotation & specs On every screen, add notes for the developer: exact padding values, font sizes, animation durations, color hex codes, icon sizes, gesture descriptions.	
Day 14	Export assets & final handoff Export all icons as SVG. Export illustrations as PNG @1x, @2x, @3x. Export app icon in all required sizes. Write a short design decisions doc.	
<i>Deliverable: Handoff checklist: all screens complete, all states covered, all assets exported, prototype linked, spacing annotated, developer has Figma view access.</i>		

RECOMMENDED TOOLS

Figma
 Primary design tool

Wireframes, hi-fi design, prototype, handoff — all in one. Free plan works for 1 designer. Use Dev Mode for developer handoff.

FigJam User flows & IA mapping	Built into Figma. Use on Day 3 for mapping screens and user flows before opening design files.
Unsplash + Iconify Free assets	Unsplash for placeholder images. Iconify Figma plugin for 150,000+ free icons including Material and Phosphor sets.
Notion Design documentation	Keep research doc, persona doc, and design decisions doc here. Link to Figma files. Developer and designer share one workspace.

KEY CANVAS DESIGN RULES

- > The toolbar must never cover more than 10% of canvas height — users are drawing, not tapping buttons.
- > Toolbar should auto-hide after 3 seconds of drawing — full screen canvas is the power feature.
- > The horizontal page strip at the bottom should show page thumbnails so users know where they are.
- > Rotation control should be a single tap, not buried in a menu — it is a core differentiator.
- > Sync indicator must always be visible on canvas — cloud icon in corner showing synced / syncing / offline.

Designer must complete Figma handoff by Day 14. Developer starts Day 15. No exceptions.